Signé par Em

No. 13

COLLECTION

BUYERS

The
Buy

Notary, in
the full bu

2026 EDITION

BEFORE YOU BEGIN

Important notice

This guide is provided for informational and educational purposes only. It presents general information about real estate in Quebec and does not constitute personalized real estate, legal, tax or financial advice. Every real estate situation is different, and you should consult the appropriate professionals before making a decision about a transaction.

COLLECTION BUYERS · GUIDE NO. 13

The Real Costs of Buying

Notary, inspection, adjustments and more — the full budget, no surprises

The displayed price is only the beginning. Between the down payment and the keys, a series of very real costs are added - and forgetting them is one of the main sources of stress when making a first purchase.

This guide provides a complete overview of closing costs and start-up expenses, with orders of magnitude for proper budgeting.

Each chapter ends with a lined “My Notes” page to build YOUR complete purchasing budget.

The displayed price is never the actual cost of a purchase. This guide lists all the costs - around the transaction, the welcome tax, the start-up, then the recurring costs - to build a complete budget without unpleasant surprises.

The amounts (2026 edition) are orders of magnitude: have your specific case calculated by your notary and your broker.

CHAPTER

Fees paid around the transaction

> *Identify the costs directly linked to the purchase.*

- Notary fees (deed of sale, mortgage deed, verifications).
- Pre-purchase inspection and, if necessary, specialized expertise (roof, pyrite, etc.).
- Up-to-date certificate of location, if a new one is required (land surveyor).
- Appraisal of the property if required by the lender.
- Adjustments: municipal/school taxes already paid by the seller, remaining fuel oil, condo charges.

These amounts are generally paid upon signature (except the welcome tax, invoiced later).

These fees all fall around the same time, around the transaction: plan for them in cash, in addition to the down payment. A written estimate from your notary and your broker, from the start, saves you the stressful question of "how much should I bring" the day before signing.

> EMILIE'S ADVICE
>
> *Ask your notary for an estimated "statement of disbursements" before signing. Seeing all the costs at once avoids unpleasant surprises on the big day.*

CHAPTER

Welcome tax, apart

> *Never forget this item invoiced after the purchase.*

Transfer duties (welcome tax) are not paid at the notary: the municipality sends a separate invoice, a few weeks to a few months later. On an average priced property, this often represents several thousand dollars (see the dedicated guide for the calculation).

The welcome tax deserves a separate line because it arrives AFTER the purchase, by municipal bill: many forget it in their budget and are surprised. Put the amount aside as soon as the transaction is completed - this is one of the most common cash flow surprises for new owners.

> EMILIE'S ADVICE
>
> *Put the estimated amount of the welcome tax aside upon signing, in a separate account. It's the classic trap: the bill arrives after the move.*

CHAPTER

Start-up expenses

> *Anticipate the cost of "taking possession".*

- Home insurance active upon taking possession.
- Connections and transfers (Hydro-Quebec, internet, etc.).
- Moving (truck, movers, boxes).
- Locks, first purchases (curtains, missing appliances, small jobs).
- Initial maintenance reserve (~1%/year of the value, to be provisioned).

Start-up expenses (insurance, connections, locks, small purchases, initial work) add up quickly in the first weeks. Plan a dedicated envelope so as not to finance your move on credit, at the worst time.

> EMILIE'S ADVICE
>
> *Keep an emergency cushion AFTER purchase. Many new owners arrive at the keys empty-handed; an unforeseen event in the first year is not a question of "if", but "when".*

CHAPTER

Build your complete purchasing budget

> *Combine all positions into one number.*

Your total budget = down payment + closing costs (notary, inspection, adjustments, certificate) + welcome tax + start-up expenses + emergency cushion. It's this overall number, not just the down payment, that determines whether you're truly ready.

By calculating it early, you avoid the most stressful scenario: having just enough for the entry, and not everything else.

Put it all together in one number: down payment + closing costs + startup + cushion. It's that total - not just the sticker price or the mortgage - that determines whether you buy comfortably or tight. A complete, written budget protects you from unpleasant surprises.

> EMILIE'S ADVICE
>
> *Make your complete purchasing budget BEFORE shopping seriously. It's what tells you what price range you're actually comfortable in - not just your pre-approval.*

CHAPTER

After purchase: recurring costs

> *Forecast the actual cost of the property.*

Purchase costs are one-off; owning property is also **recurring costs** to include in your monthly budget:

- **Taxes** municipal and school.
- **Home insurance**.
- **Energy** (heating, electricity).
- **Maintenance** current and co-ownership charges, if applicable.

An “affordable” upfront purchase can become burdensome if these recurring costs are underestimated.

Owning also means recurring costs: municipal and school taxes, insurance, energy, maintenance, co-ownership charges if applicable. An “affordable” purchase at the start can become burdensome if these monthly costs are underestimated: calculate them before committing.

> EMILIE'S ADVICE
>
> *Add up all the actual monthly costs, not just the mortgage, before committing. It is this total that will determine whether you live comfortably or tightly in your new property.*

IN PRACTICE

Action plan

> *Your next steps, concretely.*

This week

1. List all expense items for my price range.
2. Request an estimate of the notary's fees.

Within 30 days

1. Estimate the welcome tax and reserve it mentally.
2. Assemble my total purchasing budget, cushion included.

Then

1. Validate this budget with Emilie and my mortgage broker.

For a budget without surprises

1. Obtain a written estimate of all my closing costs before bidding.
2. Reserve the welcome tax and a cushion upon transaction.

REFERENCES

Resources & glossary

- Closing costs: notary, inspection, adjustments, certificate of location.
- Adjustments: reimbursement to the seller of sums paid in advance.
- Statement of disbursements: notarial estimate of costs upon signature.
- Welcome tax: charged separately after purchase.
- Emergency cushion: reserve for unforeseen events after purchase.

- Closing costs: notary, welcome tax, adjustments, inspection, insurance.
- Adjustments: taxes and fees paid in advance by the seller, refunded pro rata.
- Recurring costs: taxes, insurance, energy, maintenance, co-ownership charges.
- Emergency cushion: reserve for unforeseen events in the first months.
- Taking possession: moment when insurance and connections must be active.

GO FURTHER

Quiz - test yourself

1. The notary's fees cover:

A) The move

B) The deed of sale, the mortgage deed and the verifications

C) The welcome tax

D) Car insurance

2. The adjustments to the notary concern in particular:

A) The color of the walls

B) Taxes already paid by the seller, fuel oil, condo charges

C) The rent

D) Salary

3. The welcome tax is paid:

A) At the notary

B) By municipal invoice, after purchase

C) Every month

D) Never

4. Home insurance must be active:

A) One year later

B) Upon taking possession

C) Never

D) Only in winter

5. The starting maintenance reserve is approximately:

A) 0%

B) 1%/year of the value

C) 25%

D) 50%

6. The total purchasing budget includes:

A) The down payment alone

B) Down payment + closing costs + welcome tax + startup + cushion

C) The mortgage alone

D) Nothing more than the price

7. The classic trap is:

A) Too much saving

B) Have just enough for the entrance and nothing for the rest

C) Pay cash

D) Too much insurance

8. An estimated statement of disbursements comes from:

A) The municipality

B) The notary

C) The inspector

D) The neighbor

Answers

1. B - The notary prepares the deeds and verifies the titles (chap. 1).

2. B - The seller is reimbursed for what he paid in advance (chap. 1).

3. B - Separate invoice, after the transaction (chap. 2).

4. B - Obligatory upon possession (chap. 3).

5. B - Around 1%/year to be provisioned (chap. 3).

6. B - It is the overall figure that counts (chap. 4).

7. B - We forget the costs beyond the down payment (chap. 4).

8. B - The notary can estimate it before signing (chap. 1).

Make informed decisions.
Choose with confidence.
Move forward without regret.

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